

JUDGES FORM - SHORT STORY WRITING

☐ OPEN ☒ U/16
(Please ✓ the appropriate box)

Word Count: 1,493

Name:	<i>Samantha Reine Cubia Yan</i>	D.O.B.	<i>10/12/2011</i>
School:	<i>Victory Life Christian School Ltd</i>	Cust Code:	<i>VIC5282</i>
Title of Entry:	<i>The Lord Sees All</i>		

(JUDGES! Please remember that entries MUST be consistent with a Biblical Worldview)

AREAS OF EVALUATION		POINTS	
		POSSIBLE	AWARDED
I. Theme			
A. Story has an evangelistic, Biblical or historical theme	10		
II. Composition			
A. There is at least one life-like character	5		
B. Details of setting (place, time) are woven into the action of the story	10		
C. There is a well-planned and well-developed plot.	15		
D. There is a main conflict	10		
E. All incidents build to a climax that resolves the conflict	10		
F. Story indicates creativity on the part of the author	10		
G. Degree of Difficulty	10		
III. Mechanics			
A. Neatness, general appearance	5		
B. Spelling, punctuation, and grammar (subject-verb agreement, pronoun agreement, no misplaced modifiers, etc.)	15		
IV. Presentation (NOTE: As many as 10 points may be subtracted if the short story is not between 600-1500 words in length, word count is not stated, and/or is not typed double spaced on plain white paper.)	-10		
TOTAL POINTS	100		
COMMENT:			
Judge's Name:	Judges Signature:		



The Lord Sees All.

Written by: Samantha Reine Cabia Yan
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Samuel Robbins knew it was wrong, and God is always watching. However, when a man from the Casa Leone says your family owes money, right and wrong don't matter. One mistake, one missed payment, only made his family's debt pile higher. He *had* to steal, or else his family would die by the organization's blood-stained hands. This was what had driven him into this cramped van in the first place.

Samuel wasn't the only victim, his friends—Eric and Ethan—were also chained by past familial debt. As Monday evening settled in, the three of them huddled together to review their plan for stealing the Savoy Crown Diamond necklace—worth three hundred million Euros. The plan was simple: Samuel and Ethan would enter Banca d'Italia undetected, steal the necklace from the vault, and escape through the back entrance.

"Samuel, this isn't right!" An acquainted voice exclaimed in his head, one that he thought he buried months ago.

"But what could I do in this situation? It's hopeless!"

Ethan paced the room anxiously, gripping his hair in his hands. Samuel couldn't blame him for being stressed. At the rear end of the van sat Eric quietly, his eyes fixed upon the wall in front of him. He was planning something, and they didn't know what.

Banca D'Italia stood tall and menacing beneath the moon's glow. Armed guards watched the foyer, prepared for any threat, yet paid little attention when a delivery truck pulled into the driveway. After clearing security, Samuel and Ethan stepped out carrying boxes labelled "IT equipment" and slipped through the rear entrance with ease.

They hadn't gone far when they heard the voices of guards rapidly approaching.

"Leave me." Ethan said, pulling out his pistol from his holster.

"Huh?! What do you mean 'leave me?'" Samuel hissed, pointing an accusatory finger at his friend angrily.

"Can you hold off the guards then?"

"But you'll *die!*"

Placing his hands on Samuel's shoulders, Ethan shook him gently with an easy grin.

"Look, just go and finish the mission. I'll be fine." Nodding hesitantly, Samuel turned to leave but suddenly a loud booming voice reverberated across the hallway.

"Hey, you two! Stop!"

Samuel spun sharply on his heel and bolted in the opposite direction, Ethan and the security guards' shouts echoing behind him. Bullets were shot, and unfamiliar blood was spilled onto the pristine marble floor as he veered right. "*You're too slow!*" A contemptuous voice in his head whispered adversely.

BANG!

"*No weapon formed against you will prevail,*" that infuriatingly distinct voice spoke, cascading over his body like armour.

The ominous noise of a gunshot resonated past him, almost nicking his shoulder. "*Did He just...?*" Samuel heaved a relieved sigh and swung left instead, dead-end. With no options left, Samuel searched the wall until he heard a *click*. The wall had opened to reveal a secret passageway; he didn't think twice.

A spiral staircase winding downwards greeted him. Descending slowly to the bottom, he abruptly stopped when he saw the golden vault in front of him. He hurriedly punched the

code into the keypad, rationale flying out the window. Before him, the vault slowly cracked open.

Inside, the Savoy Crown Diamond Necklace sparkled beneath the vault's white light, its diamonds scattering dazzling brilliance and regal elegance. His heart resisted, but allure prevailed. Samuel stepped forward cautiously.

"INTRUDER DETECTED. ACTIVATING EMERGENCY DEFENSE SYSTEM." The automated voice whirred to life as he stepped on an unassuming tile. Lasers activated immediately, shrouding the room in a bright red glow.

Samuel let out an exasperated groan, massaging his temple with his index finger. "Ugh!" With another frustrated sigh, Samuel moved instinctively. He ducked, turned, and twisted with flawless precision.

Then suddenly he heard it—

Another gunshot.

Pain exploded through his leg, and Samuel fell to the ground, gasping. He turned and saw *him*. Eric stood in the doorway holding a pistol, his hand trembling. "Eric?" The pain in his leg addled his thoughts. "I thought..."

Eric stepped closer, his composure failing. "I-I'm sorry, Sam," His voice quivered. "I had to—I had to steal the necklace alone! My family would *die* if I didn't."

"So, you'll leave me here?" Eric nodded remorsefully; Samuel felt his heart shatter.

"Ha—hahaha!" The sound bubbled out of him ruefully, "I was just so *naive*." He paused and asked suddenly, hope arising. "Surely you remember when we used to pray together."

Their eyes met, years of friendship, hardship, and shared faith hung between them—severed. He crouched beside Samuel firmly taking the necklace, “I’m sorry, Sam.” Eric repeated, gritting his teeth.

Everything went dark.

Samuel felt hollow, drifting slowly under the darkness of his mind like a river with no end. Yet something kept him afloat.

“Samuel,” the comforting voice called—warm and familiar; God’s voice.

Turning away from the light he said solemnly, “I thought you left me.”

“I would never leave you, nor forsake you.”

Suddenly all of his memories came flooding back, the time he spent on his knees in prayer, praising the Lord with his family, and moments of trust even in fear. “I’m sorry,” tears welled up in his eyes.

A candescent hand reached out to him. “You were never beyond My reach,” the voice said lovingly. Beaming, Samuel took His hand without hesitation.

“Wake up Samuel.”

The sound of hurried steps, fabric tearing, and someone yelling his name made Samuel’s head spin. He felt something warm press against his wound, making him whimper quietly in pain. Samuel could vaguely remember that he was being lifted onto a heated back.

“Samuel, stay awake.” The figure, or Ethan, urged kindly. He hastily exited the vault and raced up the stairs as quickly as he could. Soon they were back in that dreaded hallway, but suddenly he found a bullet lodged in his bicep. He grimaced in pain.

“They stole the necklace!”

Gunfire continued ferociously, but Ethan only cared about getting him and Samuel safely out of the bank. The onslaught of bullets only stopped when they made a swift turn to the left, where the exit sign shone insultingly. However, Ethan didn’t expect to be surrounded by police officers the moment he stepped out of the bank.

“You two are under arrest for robbery!” A man with a heavy accent spoke, holding a gun to his face.

Time had passed since that incident. The Casa Leone had collapsed, and the boss had been arrested. Their families’ debts were finally erased and they were free, but their pasts still remain—lingering.

Samuel and Ethan served six years in prison; spent their time in uncomfortable cells and scrubbing dirty dishes. During that time, Samuel reconnected with God—talking to him about his recent troubles. He also led Ethan back to the Lord, and he seemed *happier*—he put his strength to good use, helping carry boxes around the prison with a bright smile. Samuel was overjoyed seeing his friend flourish with God’s assistance.

When Samuel was released, the first thing he saw was his family. He hadn’t felt such overwhelming joy in years as he fell into his family’s arms. More than anything, he thanked God for keeping them safe.

Weeks later, Samuel strolled along the quiet streets of Rome—freer than ever. He stumbled across an old church minutes later, his head turning in curiosity. As he drew closer to the steps, there sat someone achingly familiar.

“I never thought I would see you again,” murmured the man sitting on the steps.

He felt his eye twitch, “you left me to die!”

“And I’m sorry, Samuel. Okay?!” Eric exclaimed, gesticulating wildly.

Samuel heaved a frustrated sigh, dropping ungracefully onto the step. “I served some jail time with Ethan.”

“You know, the boss let us go free, but honestly? I’ve never felt *free*,” Samuel nodded. “I thought straying away from God would save us, but it didn’t.” Eric looked towards the run-down church doors, “do you still believe in God?”

“More than ever.” Samuel stood and extended a hand to Eric, smiling warmly. “This is where we start again, Eric.”

Eric looked sceptically at the hand raised in front of him, then took it with a grin. “This is where we start again, *Sam*.”

“Hey, God, did you lead me to the church to make things right with Eric?” Samuel pondered, thumbing the bottom of his shirt.

Yes, I did.

“Just like what Colossians 3:23 said: ‘Forbearing one another, and forgiving one another, if any man quarrel against any: even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye.’” Samuel smiled faintly at the thought of the verse, continuing his trek back home.

That evening Samuel when returned to his home, its cozy warmth welcomed him with open arms. Everything felt different not because the past was erased, but because he understood it. God is always watching, and no matter how lost you are—he *will* bring you back. The Lord sees all.

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